

# Why can't the water AI uses be recycled?

Posted by u/just\_JJ\_style • • 0 points • 5 comments

I'll admit I don't know a lot about how AI data centers work, but what I do know is that they use a lot of water to stop overheating. What happens to the water afterwards tho? Once it's done its job, is it contaminated and why can't it be reused/recycled out to the public?

## Comments

u/Ramtakwitha2 • 1 points • 2025-08-01 06:21 UTC

The water isn't so much used up as it evaporates. It's just no longer in the area where it originally was. Just about every place on earth has problems with water overconsumption.

Even Florida where you can almost just pick any old random spot in your yard and have a functional well built there, has been having issues with the water table going down noticeably even in the span of a couple years.

When the water evaporates off of a AI computer facility, it removes it from the local supply, and AI plants use such a ridiculous amount of water that if the area doesn't have water problems already, it will in a year or so.

u/vdday • 2 points • 2025-08-03 21:51 UTC

The data center that I work in uses a closed loop water system. Chilled water flows through in row chillers and the warm water gets pumped up to a HVAC system to chill it. Pretty much like a liquid cooled desktop but on a larger scale.

u/just\_JJ\_style • 2 points • 2025-08-01 06:22 UTC

Got it!! That answers everything and why it's such a problem too. Dunno why I didn't think about evaporation lol

u/Aggressive\_Size69 • 2 points • 2025-08-01 06:10 UTC

it does. Saying it 'uses' water as in it consumes water is wrong, it's more like it takes part of the limited water supply and uses it only for the datacenter, while it could be used in cities or rivers.

u/EZontheH • 5 points • 2025-08-01 06:04 UTC

It absolutely can be recovered and recycled, but right now it's cheaper to just not do that and completely fuck over the local hydrological area. Fuck you and everybody else, I'm making money over here.

u/SickdayThrowaway20 • 5 points • 2025-08-01 06:00 UTC

A cooling system using water needs to disperse the heat somewhere. Typically you either run the water through a radiator and blow air over it or you let the water evaporate into the air.

Using a radiator costs more initially and more importantly requires a much larger amount of energy, costing more to operate. Evaporative cooling is therefore much cheaper.

The negative side effects of this larger water use are often less than the negative effects of generating more electricity (especially since gas, coal, nuclear and geothermal power plants all use evaporative cooling as well)